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Bloomberg

## FREE TRADE AGREEMENT BRIGHTENS SMILES

■ UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer (right) and India's Prime Minister Narendra Modi with a trader during a business showcase event on the grounds of Chequers near Aylesbury, UK, yesterday. The UK and India signed their long-awaited free trade agreement yesterday, in a move that is expected to boost trade between the two countries by £25.5 billion and add £4.8 billion a year to the UK economy.

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## UAE condemns Israeli move on West Bank

Knesset's approval of 'Israeli sovereignty' over occupied region slammed by nations

ABU DHABI

The UAE, along with Bahrain, Egypt, Indonesia, Jordan, Nigeria, Palestine, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, the League of Arab States and the Organisation of Islamic Co-operation (OIC), strongly condemned the Israeli Knesset's approval of the declaration calling for the imposition of the so-called "Israeli sovereignty" over the occupied West Bank.

They called it a blatant and unacceptable violation of international law, and a flagrant breach of relevant UN Security Council resolutions, all of which affirm the invalidity of all measures that seek to legitimise the occupation, including settlement activities in the Palestinian territory occupied since 1967.

### No legal effect

The countries reaffirmed that Israel has no sovereignty over the Occupied Palestinian Territory, stressing that this unilateral Israeli move has no legal effect and cannot alter the legal status of the Occupied Palestinian Territory, particularly East Jerusalem, which remains

an integral part of the Territory. They also emphasised that such Israeli actions only fuel the growing tension in the region.

The countries called on the international community, including the UN Security Council and all relevant stakeholders, to uphold their legal and moral responsibilities, and implement urgent steps to halt Israel's illegal policies aimed at imposing a fait accompli by force. Furthermore, the countries reaffirmed their commitment to the two-state solution, and to the establishment of an independent, sovereign Palestinian state on the June 4, 1967 lines, with East Jerusalem as its capital. — WAM

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### SPECIAL REPORT

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## UAE banks to phase out OTPs starting today

ALL BANKS TO TRANSITION CUSTOMERS TO APP-BASED AUTHENTICATION

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR

Chief News Editor

In a major shift aimed at strengthening digital banking security, banks in the UAE will begin phasing out one-time passwords (OTPs) sent via SMS and email, starting today.

Under new guidelines from the UAE Central Bank, all banks must transition customers to app-based authentication for both domestic and international financial transactions.

The in-app authorisation allows customers to approve or reject a banking transaction directly inside their bank's mobile app — with no need to switch to SMS inbox or type in codes. The move marks a significant shift from the long-standing reliance on SMS and email OTPs — methods increasingly targeted by cyber-criminals through tactics such as SIM swapping and phishing.

While SMS OTPs can be intercepted or tricked out of users through fake websites, in-app approvals happen only inside the banking app, where phishing is much harder to pull off.

### Secure technologies

The transition will be gradual, with a complete discontinuation of SMS and email OTPs mandated by March 2026. In their place, customers will authenticate transactions through secure

The transition will be gradual, with a complete discontinuation of SMS and email OTPs mandated by March 2026.

technologies embedded within bank mobile apps.

"As per the directives issued by the UAE Central Bank, the practice of receiving OTPs via SMS or email will be phased out. Customers can now complete online transactions easily by selecting the 'Authentication via App' feature in their bank's smart application," a bank spokesperson said.

The move is part of the UAE's wider strategy to modernise its financial infrastructure and boost trust in digital banking. While the change may take some getting used to for customers familiar with traditional OTPs, banks are urging users to update their apps and start using the new in-app authentication features.

For now, SMS and email OTPs will remain available to select customers during the transition period. But over the next 8 months, these methods will be phased out entirely — making way for more secure, app-based verification.

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